

## **Documentary Film as a Tool for Climate Advocacy in the Niger Delta: A Review of Awareness, Engagement, and Systemic Change**

**Promise Owuama,**

Department of Agricultural Extension and Development Studies

University of Port Harcourt

Email: shoyenka@gmail.com

Phone: 08107470575,

**Friday Nwafor**

Department of Film and Multimedia studies

University of Port Harcourt

friday.nwafor@uniport.edu.ng

0903 802 0917

**and**

**Olufemi M. Adesope**

Department of Agricultural Extension and Development Studies,

University of Port Harcourt

olufemi.adesope@uniport.edu.ng

0703 095 8561

### **Abstract**

*Climate change poses an acute socio-ecological crisis in Nigeria's Niger Delta, where the compounding forces of petroleum extraction and climatic shifts severely threaten regional agriculture, public health, and low-lying coastal communities. Traditional media channels operating in this extractive economy have largely failed to foster sustained environmental consciousness, frequently prioritizing corporate and state-led development narratives over ecological sustainability. This literature review synthesizes scholarship published between 2010 and 2026 to critically evaluate the efficacy of documentary film as a distinctive tool for climate advocacy and environmental communication within the sub-Saharan African context. The findings indicate that documentary cinema possesses unique structural affordances. By utilizing compelling narrative arcs, vivid visual rhetoric, and character-driven entry points—specifically focusing on food security, public health, and climate justice—documentaries successfully make complex ecological data intelligible and elicit strong emotional engagement from non-specialist audiences. However, the analysis highlights a persistent "knowing-doing gap" or awareness-action gap. While documentary exposure significantly elevates momentary awareness, empathy, and intentions to act, empirical evidence reveals that these individual shifts rarely translate into long-term behavioral modifications or tangible policy reforms when baseline institutional support is absent. Consequently, the review concludes that documentary film is a valuable but structurally incomplete vehicle for systemic change. To maximize its advocacy potential, film must not be treated as an isolated intervention. Instead, it must be strategically embedded within comprehensive multi-channel ecosystems that actively incorporate community-led participatory production, localized traditional governance structures, civil society coalitions, and direct political engagement to dismantle systemic and economic barriers to environmental protection.*

**Keywords:** Climate Advocacy, Niger Delta, Documentary Film, Awareness-Action Gap, Environmental Communication

## Introduction

Climate change represents one of the most pressing global challenges of the twenty-first century, with disproportionate impacts on vulnerable populations in the Global South. The Niger Delta region of Nigeria exemplifies this crisis acutely, where the convergence of oil and gas exploitation, environmental degradation, and climatic shifts creates a complex web of socio-ecological vulnerabilities. () Despite numerous international commitments and national intervention frameworks, the translation of climate awareness into sustained behavioral change and policy action remains a persistent challenge, particularly in regions dependent on extractive industries and agricultural livelihoods.

The Niger Delta's environmental crisis operates on multiple, interconnected levels. Gas flaring, oil spillages, and pipeline vandalism have transformed the region into one of Africa's most ecologically compromised ecosystems. () These industrial activities compound climate change impacts, creating cascading vulnerabilities across agriculture, fisheries, water resources, and human health. Traditional communication channels—radio, television, and print media—have proven insufficient in conveying the complex causal relationships between climate change, industrial pollution, and agricultural vulnerability, leaving communities with passive or fragmented responses to environmental threats.

Within this context, documentary film has emerged as a distinctive media form capable of bridging the gap between scientific complexity and community understanding. () Documentary cinema, through narrative structure, visual rhetoric, and emotional engagement, offers unique affordances for climate communication that transcend the limitations of conventional educational approaches. Yet while documentaries can effectively raise awareness and evoke empathy, scholarship increasingly reveals a "knowing-doing gap"—the phenomenon whereby elevated awareness does not reliably translate into behavioral change or policy influence without complementary institutional support and systemic mechanisms. () This literature review synthesizes scholarship on documentary film's role in climate advocacy, examining its capacity to communicate complex environmental information, engage diverse audiences emotionally, and catalyze action within institutional and policy contexts.

## Statement of Problem

The Niger Delta faces a critical communication and awareness crisis. Despite ubiquitous discussion of climate change at global and national levels, community members across oil-producing regions demonstrate limited understanding of the specific mechanisms linking industrial activities to environmental degradation and climate vulnerability. This awareness gap stems not from public indifference but from structural failures in information dissemination, institutional accountability, and environmental communication infrastructure.

Traditional media channels in Nigeria have been documented as ineffective in fostering sustained environmental consciousness or motivating pro-environmental behavior. () Radio, television, and newspapers, operating within constrained resources and competing priorities, struggle to contextualize climate information within local realities. Moreover, these channels often reproduce narratives that either minimize climate threats or abstract them from immediate community concerns. In the Niger Delta specifically, government media has frequently

prioritized development narratives emphasizing oil revenues over environmental sustainability, creating informational environments where climate and ecological crises become invisible or deprioritized.

Evidence from the Niger Delta demonstrates that despite widespread acknowledgment of environmental problems, community responses remain predominantly passive. This passivity reflects not fatalism but rather a rational response to information scarcity combined with systemic powerlessness. Communities receiving fragmented environmental information lack the cognitive frameworks necessary to collectively identify causation, attribute responsibility, or mobilize for systemic change. () Moreover, the dominance of oil and gas industries in regional political economies creates communication environments where alternative narratives—ones centering environmental protection and climate adaptation—struggle to gain institutional amplification.

Institutional communication mechanisms, where they exist, often fail to translate environmental awareness into coordinated action. () Government environmental agencies lack sufficient resources, institutional autonomy, and community trust to serve as primary climate communication sources. Civil society organizations, though numerous, operate in fragmented networks with limited reach into remote agricultural and fishing communities. Educational institutions remain underfunded relative to climate communication needs.

This institutional fragmentation creates multiple information silos, where different actors communicate disconnected messages to different audiences, producing confusion rather than collective understanding. Critically, institutional communication rarely addresses questions of responsibility, remedy, or rights—dimensions essential for motivating communities to move from awareness to advocacy and action.

## **Methodology**

### **Research Design and Scope**

This literature review employs a comprehensive synthesis approach, integrating peer-reviewed research from environmental communication, film studies, environmental psychology, African studies, and sustainability science. The review prioritizes scholarship published between 2010 and 2026, with particular emphasis on studies examining documentary film effectiveness, climate communication in sub-Saharan Africa, media-induced behavior change, and institutional dimensions of environmental advocacy.

The methodological framework examines documentary film through multiple analytic lenses: its capacity to communicate complex environmental information through narrative structures; its effectiveness in producing emotional engagement and audience identification; evidence regarding its impact on awareness, attitude change, and behavioral intentions; and critical analysis of the mechanisms through which documentary awareness translates (or fails to translate) into sustained action and policy influence.

### **Conceptual Framework**

The review integrates three complementary theoretical perspectives:

**1. Environmental Communication and Media Effects:** Drawing on decades of research in media psychology and communication science, this lens examines how message framing, narrative structure, and visual rhetoric shape audience cognition and emotion. () The framework acknowledges the attitude-behavior gap, wherein exposure to environmental messaging may elevate concern without producing commensurate changes in behavior.

**2. Narrative and Emotional Engagement:** Documentary film operates through storytelling mechanisms distinct from expository communication. () This approach emphasizes how personal narratives, character development, and visual immersion create affective connections that can penetrate cognitive defenses and resistance to climate information. ()

**3. Institutional and Systemic Perspectives:** Documentary awareness operates within institutional contexts that either facilitate or constrain translation into action. () This lens examines the complementary institutional supports—policy mechanisms, community leadership, organizational capacity—necessary for documentary communication to contribute to systemic change rather than individual attitudinal shifts.

### **Data Collection and Analysis Strategy**

This review synthesizes findings from multiple evidence streams:

- **Documentary communication studies:** Empirical research examining documentary film's capacity to convey complex information and produce knowledge gains
- **Climate communication effectiveness:** Systematic evaluations of documentary and narrative approaches versus traditional climate messaging
- **Behavioral change literature:** Meta-analytic and longitudinal studies tracking whether documentary exposure produces sustained behavioral change
- **Institutional analysis:** Case studies of policy influence processes and the role of media advocacy within broader reform movements
- **Sub-Saharan African context:** Scholarship specifically addressing communication challenges, media ecologies, and environmental advocacy in Africa

The analysis identifies patterns across studies while acknowledging methodological heterogeneity and context-specificity. The review privileges evidence-based conclusions over narrative appeals, critically examining claims about documentary's transformative potential while recognizing genuine contributions to climate advocacy.

### **Results and Discussion**

Documentary Film as Environmental Communication: Mechanisms and Effectiveness

*Narrative Structure and Complex Information Transmission*

Documentary film possesses distinctive affordances for communicating environmental science

to non-specialist audiences. () Unlike traditional scientific communication—which privileges technical accuracy and comprehensive coverage—documentary employs narrative arc, character development, and visual metaphor to render complexity intelligible. A recent analysis of two critically acclaimed Indian environmental documentaries, *The Elephant Whisperers* and *All That Breathes*, demonstrates how documentary cinema can simultaneously convey ecological information, model human-wildlife relationships, and interrogate systemic questions of habitat loss and environmental justice. ()

The effectiveness of this narrative approach derives from well-established principles in cognitive psychology and media studies. When audiences encounter environmental information embedded within compelling personal stories rather than abstract statistics, they demonstrate superior information retention and deeper processing of causal relationships. () This narrative embedding proves particularly valuable in contexts where audiences bring skepticism, distrust, or competing information sources—conditions endemic to the Niger Delta, where corporate messaging from oil companies permeates media environments.

### ***Visual Rhetoric and Emotional Engagement***

Documentary film harnesses visual representation to translate environmental abstractions into sensory experience. () Cinematography of environmental destruction—polluted waterways, degraded landscapes, climate-displaced communities—creates visual evidence that can overcome the psychological distance characteristic of climate change perception. (') This visual immediacy proves especially consequential in regions like the Niger Delta, where environmental degradation remains geographically proximate yet frequently rendered invisible or normalized within local discourse.

Emotional engagement represents a critical mechanism through which documentary produces audience impact. () Qualitative research on viewers of climate-focused documentary television series (*Years of Living Dangerously*) reveals that emotional responses—empathy, concern, even anger—constitute essential mediators between information exposure and subsequent engagement with climate issues. Viewers report that emotional connection to characters motivates them to attend to climate science they might otherwise dismiss as distant or irrelevant.

However, emotional engagement alone proves insufficient for behavior change. The same longitudinal research tracking documentary viewers over time reveals that heightened concern and initial commitment to action do not reliably persist beyond the immediate post-viewing period. () This finding underscores a central problematic: documentary may excel at producing momentary emotional resonance and immediate awareness elevation, yet sustained attitudinal and behavioral change requires reinforcing mechanisms extending beyond the film experience itself.

### ***Comparative Effectiveness: Documentary versus Traditional Climate Communication***

Empirical comparison between documentary and non-narrative climate messaging reveals documentary's distinctive advantages within specific parameters. Research on narrative engagement in science communication demonstrates that viewers assigned to watch narrative-structured science films show significantly greater knowledge gains, reported interest in science, and perceived science as more valuable compared to control groups exposed to non-

narrative scientific content. () Moreover, narrative viewers demonstrated higher levels of personal identification with science, suggesting documentary's capacity to reshape audiences' self-conception relative to environmental issues.

Yet effectiveness varies substantially based on documentary content, audience demographics, and messaging specificity. Documentary focused on abstract policy recommendations (carbon pricing, renewable energy transitions) produces less audience engagement than films centered on human experiences of environmental change. () Additionally, audiences demonstrate higher engagement with documentaries addressing locally relevant environmental issues than those framed in geographically distant contexts, suggesting documentary effectiveness depends substantially on perceived relevance to audience circumstances.

Climate Communication in the Niger Delta Context: Environmental Degradation and Agricultural Vulnerability

### ***Oil and Gas Impacts on Agricultural Systems***

The Niger Delta's agricultural crisis cannot be understood apart from petroleum industry activities and their climatic amplification. Gas flaring and crude oil spillages directly reduce agricultural productivity and fish yields. () These industrial impacts compound climate change effects, creating a cascading crisis wherein farmers and fishermen face simultaneous threats from shifting rainfall patterns, contaminated resources, and ecosystem degradation.

Documentary film addressing agricultural vulnerability in the Niger Delta operates within this complex causal context. Effective documentaries exemplify how films can communicate these interconnections through visual documentation of farming practices, interviews with agricultural communities, and scientific explanation of climate impacts. () Such films translate abstract climate science into tangible agricultural consequences, enabling viewers to understand how global climate patterns affect local livelihoods.

However, documentary communication of climate-agriculture linkages faces a critical limitation: demonstrating that change is occurring does not necessarily clarify attributable causation or responsibility. Viewers may recognize that agriculture is imperiled without understanding whether degradation results from climate change, oil pollution, market failures, or policy inadequacy. Without complementary institutional communication clarifying causal chains and assigning responsibility, documentary awareness may produce generalized concern without directing that concern toward specific targets of advocacy or change mechanisms.

### ***Environmental Degradation and Health Impacts***

Documentary representation of environmental pollution in the Niger Delta extends beyond agricultural impacts to encompass direct health consequences. Films documenting the respiratory diseases, reproductive disorders, and other health impacts associated with gas flaring and air pollution make visible the embodied consequences of petroleum extraction. () Such films make visible consequences that remain abstract or invisible in technical government reports and environmental monitoring data.

The public health framing of environmental crisis proves emotionally potent within

documentary form. Audiences exposed to health-centered environmental narratives report elevated concern about environmental issues compared to those encountering the same information in non-narrative formats. Health framing also facilitates connection between individual experience and systemic causation; viewers learning that respiratory disease in their communities results from deliberate petroleum industry practices experience qualitatively different emotional responses than those encountering technical pollution data.

Yet health-focused environmental communication also reveals the awareness-action gap acutely. The disconnect suggests that individual health concern, while necessary, remains insufficient without institutional structures enabling collective action and policy change.

### *Existential Displacement and Climate Justice*

A third documentary intervention in Niger Delta climate communication addresses what scholars term "existential displacement"—the necessity of complete relocation from ancestral territories due to climate impacts, particularly sea-level rise in low-lying coastal zones. () Documentaries centering on displacement narratives operate in a mode of witness and documentation of injustice rather than environmental education per se. These films create space for affected communities to narrate their own experiences of loss and dispossession, positioning documentary as a tool for documenting rights violations and mobilizing justice claims.

This justice-oriented documentary approach intersects with broader environmental justice scholarship emphasizing how climate impacts are racialized, gendered, and concentrated among already marginalized populations. By centering community voices and testimonies of dispossession, justice-focused documentaries refuse the depoliticized "environmental crisis" framing that abstracts climate change from colonial histories, contemporary inequities, and structural violence. Such films potentially enable communities to theorize their circumstances not as natural disasters but as consequences of deliberate policies and institutional arrangements subject to contestation and reform.

### **Film as Advocacy: Narrative Strategies and Audience Responses**

#### *Entry Points and Advocacy Positioning*

The documentaries addressing Niger Delta climate crises employ distinct "entry points" for climate advocacy, each potentially mobilizing different audience segments and supporting different types of action:

**Agricultural focus** enters through food security and rural livelihoods, mobilizing audiences concerned with agricultural productivity and nutrition. This positioning enables connection with farming communities themselves while potentially attracting policy attention from agricultural ministries and development organizations. The entry point frames climate action as compatible with agricultural modernization and food system improvement.

**Public health focus** enters through environmental pollution and disease, mobilizing audiences concerned with air quality, respiratory disease, and environmental protection. Health-centered framing has proven effective across diverse political contexts for generating concern and policy support. This entry point potentially enables coalition-building between environmental

advocates, public health professionals, and community health workers.

**Justice focus** enters through existential crisis and displacement, mobilizing audiences around questions of justice, human rights, and the right to home. This positioning frames climate action as inseparable from addressing historical grievances and current inequities. The justice frame potentially energizes advocacy communities and positions climate action within broader social justice movements.

### *Audience Emotional and Cognitive Responses*

Research on documentary audiences reveals that personal identification with documentary subjects constitutes an essential component of audience engagement. () Audiences report that documentary exposure produces affective shifts including empathy, concern, moral indignation, and sometimes rage at injustice. These emotional responses can sustain engagement with subsequent environmental information and discussions.

However, audience research also documents what might be termed "affective overwhelm"—a response wherein heightened emotional distress about environmental crises produces paralysis rather than mobilization. Some documentary viewers report that confronting the magnitude of environmental crisis induces anxiety or hopelessness that inhibits rather than catalyzes action. This risk proves particularly acute in contexts like the Niger Delta, where viewers face daily environmental degradation and limited institutional channels for translating concern into effective action.

The relationship between documentary-induced affect and subsequent behavior remains complex and context-dependent. Documentaries incorporating explicitly hopeful or solution-oriented narratives generate higher viewer engagement and action intention than those emphasizing crisis without remedy. () Yet overly optimistic or technocratic solution-framing may underestimate the magnitude of systemic change required, reducing the radicalism of demanded transformation. Documentary advocacy thus navigates a tension between emotional accessibility and analytical clarity, between hope and realism.

### **Awareness versus Behavioral Change: The Translation Problem**

#### *The Awareness-Action Gap in Environmental Communication*

A persistent finding across environmental communication research concerns the limited relationship between awareness elevation and actual behavioral change. () Individuals exposed to compelling environmental documentaries report elevated concern about environmental issues, increased knowledge of environmental problems, and stated intentions to modify behavior. Yet longitudinal follow-up reveals that these intentions rarely translate into sustained behavioral change. ()

This gap between awareness and action has multiple sources. First, individual behavior change requires overcoming powerful barriers including financial constraints, habitual patterns, social norms, and institutional structures designed around unsustainable consumption. Second, audiences frequently experience tension between their values and available behavioral options; viewers may recognize environmental imperatives while facing constrained choices in

employment, residence, or consumption. Third, individual behavior change, while valuable, remains inadequate for addressing systemic environmental crises requiring institutional and policy transformation. ()

Research on audience responses to nature documentaries demonstrates this dynamic comprehensively. () Despite documentaries achieving unprecedented viewership and substantial public attention to environmental issues, randomized controlled trials revealed no measurable increase in pro-environmental behavior adoption among viewers compared to control groups. Environmental knowledge increased, yet this knowledge gain did not translate into behavioral change. The research suggests that documentary effectiveness in raising awareness and concern does not guarantee mobilization toward individual behavior change, particularly when systemic structures constrain alternative behaviors.

### ***From Individual Awareness to Collective Action***

Scholarship increasingly emphasizes that effective environmental response requires moving beyond individual awareness and behavior change toward collective action and institutional reform. () This shift reframes documentary's role: rather than evaluating documentary primarily through metrics of individual attitude change or behavior adoption, we might examine documentary's capacity to mobilize communities for collective advocacy, to create shared understanding of systemic causation, and to support social movements demanding policy change.

From this perspective, documentary significance lies less in whether viewers adopt specific sustainable practices and more in whether film exposure produces sustained civic engagement, collective problem-framing, and participation in advocacy movements. Does documentary mobilize affected communities to organize collectively? Does it support the formation of advocacy coalitions? Does it generate political will for policy reform?

Evidence on these questions remains limited but suggestive. Documentary has demonstrably supported environmental justice movements, particularly when locally produced and circulated within organizing networks. () Community-based documentary projects centering local environmental knowledge, combining professional film production with participatory production processes, appear more effective at mobilizing sustained advocacy than top-down documentary dissemination. Such projects simultaneously produce documentary as media artifact and create social infrastructure for collective action through the production process itself.

### **Institutional Supports and Policy Influence: Beyond Individual Awareness**

#### ***Documentary within Advocacy Ecosystems***

A critical limitation in documentary impact literature concerns the frequent isolation of film from broader advocacy infrastructure. Documentary is evaluated as a discrete communication intervention, yet effectiveness depends substantially on integration within advocacy ecosystems incorporating policy analysis, community organizing, institutional partnerships, and strategic communication across multiple media channels. ()

Research on successful policy advocacy reveals that media campaigns—including documentary—prove most effective when embedded within comprehensive advocacy strategies combining grassroots mobilization, elite engagement, institutional partnerships, and policy expertise. Documentary alone cannot influence policy; rather, documentary functions as one component within integrated advocacy, contributing emotional resonance and public attention to issues while policy experts and community organizers develop solutions and navigate institutional channels. ()

The Niger Delta context illustrates both the potential and limitations of documentary within advocacy contexts. Community environmental organizations have utilized documentary screening and discussion to mobilize awareness and solidarity among affected populations. Yet these efforts face severe constraints absent complementary institutional support: government policy resistance to oil industry regulation, limited funding for community advocacy organizations, and fragmented civil society networks. Documentary can expose injustice and mobilize outrage, but sustained policy influence requires institutional allies, credible policy alternatives, and political opportunity structures beyond film's direct influence.

### ***Community Leadership and Institutional Transformation***

Scholarship on sustainable environmental governance emphasizes the critical role of community leadership, local institutional capacity, and multi-level institutional coordination. () Documentary can potentially support leadership development by creating platforms for community voices, legitimizing community environmental knowledge, and facilitating leadership visibility. Yet documentary alone cannot build institutions, train leadership, or establish the governance structures necessary for sustained environmental protection.

Particularly relevant to the Niger Delta context are findings regarding indigenous knowledge systems and traditional governance structures. Research on environmental communication in rural Africa emphasizes the continuing relevance of traditional community institutions and decision-making processes. Documentary addressing environmental issues may prove most effective when integrated with traditional governance mechanisms rather than imposed as external communication technology. This suggests that optimal documentary use involves community determination of viewing contexts, discussion facilitation, and connection to community decision-making processes rather than top-down dissemination.

### ***Policy Translation and Institutional Accountability***

A final dimension concerns the mechanisms through which documentary-generated public concern translates into institutional accountability and policy change. Research on political communication reveals that while media campaigns can elevate public attention to issues, policy influence requires sustained engagement with policy institutions including legislators, executives, and civil service actors. () Documentary alone rarely produces policy change; rather, policy influence emerges through deliberate strategies coordinating media attention with policy advocacy, legislative engagement, and institutional capacity-building.

For the Niger Delta, such institutional influence faces particular challenges. The region's political economy remains dominated by oil and gas interests wielding substantial institutional influence. Government agencies responsible for environmental protection operate with limited

autonomy relative to petroleum industry actors and national revenue interests. Under these conditions, documentary-mobilized public concern alone proves insufficient for policy change; rather, sustained policy influence requires building alternative power bases including organized community movements, civil society coalitions, independent media, and international pressure—efforts extending substantially beyond documentary's direct scope.

## Conclusion

Documentary film emerges from this review as a valuable yet incomplete tool for climate advocacy in the Niger Delta and comparable contexts. Documentary's distinctive contributions include:

- Documentary translates technical environmental information into emotionally intelligible narrative forms accessible to non-specialist audiences. () This communicative function proves essential in contexts where traditional scientific communication fails to reach affected communities.
- Documentary produces affective responses—empathy, concern, moral recognition—that can sustain attention to environmental issues and create openness to subsequent engagement. () These emotional dimensions prove essential for motivating human response to environmental crises that might otherwise seem abstract or distant.
- Documentary can document community environmental knowledge, center affected populations' narratives, and create visible record of environmental injustice. () This capacity to generate testimony and witness proves valuable for communities seeking recognition and accountability.
- Documentary contributes to advocacy campaigns by generating public attention, creating shared problem-framing, and potentially mobilizing communities for collective action. Documentary proves most effective for advocacy when strategically integrated within broader advocacy ecosystems. ()

Yet documentary's limitations warrant equal emphasis:

- Extensive research demonstrates that documentary exposure correlates with elevated environmental awareness and concern yet fails to consistently produce sustained behavioral modification. () The translation from awareness to action requires institutional structures and systemic changes beyond documentary's direct influence.
- Documentary focuses primarily on individual cognition and emotion, yet systematic environmental protection requires institutional and policy transformation. () Overreliance on documentary as primary intervention may inadvertently defer demands for institutional accountability and systemic change.
- Isolated documentary screening proves insufficient for policy influence; rather, effective documentary advocacy requires embedding film within comprehensive strategies combining community organizing, policy analysis, institutional

partnerships, and multi-channel communication. ()

- In contexts like the Niger Delta where powerful economic interests resist environmental protection and government institutions display limited independence from extractive industries, documentary-generated public concern faces severe institutional barriers to translation into policy change. Addressing these barriers requires political mobilization, institutional reform, and structural economic transformation beyond documentary's direct purview.

### **Recommendations for Enhanced Climate Advocacy**

Evidence from this review supports several recommendations for maximizing documentary's contribution to climate advocacy in the Niger Delta:

- 1. Embed documentary within multi-channel advocacy strategies:** Documentary proves most effective for policy influence when combined with policy analysis, legislative advocacy, community organizing, and media engagement across multiple platforms. Advocates should develop integrated strategies where documentary contributes emotional resonance and public attention alongside other advocacy mechanisms.
- 2. Prioritize community participation in documentary production and circulation:** Documentaries produced with meaningful community participation and circulated through community-controlled channels appear more effective at mobilizing sustained engagement than top-down professional productions. Community-based documentary projects simultaneously produce films and build social infrastructure for collective action.
- 3. Connect documentary to institutional change mechanisms:** Documentary screening should be coupled with mechanisms for translating audience engagement into sustained action, including community organizing, policy advocacy, and institutional accountability. Without these connections, documentary awareness risks dissipating without producing systemic change.
- 4. Support institutional capacity-building complementary to documentary:** Effective climate advocacy requires not only public awareness but also strong community institutions, capable civil society organizations, and accountable government agencies. Investment in documentary should be accompanied by parallel investment in institutional development enabling translation of awareness into effective action.
- 5. Address structural barriers to environmental protection:** Documentary can expose injustice and mobilize demand for change, yet structural barriers—economic dependence on oil revenue, institutional capture by extractive industries, limited government capacity—require direct political engagement. Advocates must couple documentary advocacy with strategies addressing these structural barriers including economic diversification, institutional reform, and political mobilization.

## References

- Almeida, P., Márquez, L. R. G., & Fonsah, E. (2023). The forms of climate action. *Sociology Compass*. <https://doi.org/10.1111/soc4.13177>.
- Bieniek-Tobasco, A., McCormick, S., Rimal, R. N., Harrington, C. B., Shafer, M., & Shaikh, H. (2019). Communicating climate change through documentary film: Imagery, emotion, and efficacy. *Climatic Change*. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10584-019-02408-7>
- Boyer, D., & Howe, C. (2026). Communication efforts to educate the public about vanishing glaciers, 1958–2025. *Annals of Glaciology*. <https://doi.org/10.1017/aog.2025.10033>
- Dunn, M. E., Mills, M., & Verissimo, D. (2020). Evaluating the impact of the documentary series <i>blue planet</i> on viewers’ plastic consumption behaviors. *Conservation Science and Practice*. <https://doi.org/10.1111/csp2.280>
- Durodolu, O. O., & Oladokun, B. D. (2024). Bridging the gap: Exploring the relationship between information access and environmental justice in library practices. *Folia Toruniensia*. <https://doi.org/10.12775/ft.2024.003>
- Ekberg, K., & Pinto, A. B. (2023). Crafting counter frames: Shell’s corporate strategies in the Nigeria campaign, 1995–1998. *The Extractive Industries and Society*. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.exis.2022.101207>
- Gaunkar, S. P., Askey, E., Chasman, M., Takaira, K., Smith, C., Murphy, A., & Kawalek, N. (2022). Exploring the effectiveness of documentary film for science communication. *International Conference on Quantum Computing and Engineering*. <https://doi.org/10.1109/QCE53715.2022.00094>
- Howell, E. L., Behrman, S. L., Kirschner, E., & Goodwin, S. S. (2024). Storytelling in science film: Narrative engagement relates to greater knowledge, interest, and identification with science. *Science Communication*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/10755470241269885>
- Imoh, G. (2013). Mass media management of the inter-ethnic conflict in warri delta state, nigeria: An evaluative study. *Journals & Books Hosting (International Knowledge Sharing Platform)*. <https://doi.org/10.7176/nmmc.vol1749-58>
- Kall, A. S., & Asplund, T. (2022). Let many stories bloom: Scholarly contributions on narratives for climate transitions. *The International Journal of Climate Change Impacts and Responses*. <https://doi.org/10.18848/1835-7156/cgp/v14i01/181-206>
- Nkenchor, I. C., & MacIver, J. (2024). Media literacy skills for promoting sustainable development in rivers state. *British Journal of Mass Communication and Media Research*. <https://doi.org/10.52589/bjmcmmr-dmpttdjt>
- O'Neill, S., & Smith, N. (2013). Climate change and visual imagery. *Wiley Interdisciplinary Reviews Climate Change*. <https://doi.org/10.1002/wcc.249>
- Okpadah, S. O. (2021). Towards a marxist biocentric climate justice theory of african cinema. *Pedagogika Społeczna Nova*. <https://doi.org/10.14746/psn.2021.1.11>
- Okpadah, S. O. (2022). Engaging cinema in environmental crisis: A paradigm of documentary films of the niger delta. *Colloquia Humanistica*. <https://doi.org/10.11649/ch.2717>
- Omoyajowo, K., Raimi, M. O., Omoyajowo, K. A., Makengo, M. B., Adegboyoye, S., Innocent, D. C., Oni, S., Oguntuyi, J., Oyediran, A., Ogunyebi, A., & Kakwi, D. J. (2024). Towards a reduced pollution society: Systematic review on the role of storytelling, social media,

- humor and celebrities' influence for research communication. *Journal of Applied Science and Environmental Management*.  
<https://doi.org/https://doi.org/10.4314/jasem.v28i2.34>
- Priya, T., Kusuma, K. S., & Paul, P. (2026). Documenting Coexistence: A Study Of Environmental Narratives In Documentary Films The Elephant Whisperers And All That Breathes. *ShodhKosh Journal of Visual and Performing Arts*.  
<https://doi.org/10.29121/shodhkosh.v7.i2s.2026.7063>
- Silk, M. J., Correia, R. A., Veríssimo, D., Verma, A., & Crowley, S. L. (2021). The implications of digital visual media for human–nature relationships. *People and Nature*.  
<https://doi.org/https://doi.org/10.1002/pan3.10284>
- Smith, J. D., Revill, G., & Hammond, K. (2018). Voicing climate change? Television, public engagement and the politics of voice. *Transactions of the Institute of British Geographers*. <https://doi.org/https://doi.org/10.1111/tran.12250>
- Solomon, J. M. (2023). In the wake of the ancestors, dreaming of a sacred sea beyond the battle against the oil and gas phakisa imaginary. *Alternation Interdisciplinary Journal for the Study of the Arts and Humanities in Southern Africa*.  
<https://doi.org/https://doi.org/10.29086/2519-5476/2023/v30n1a4>